

MORNING EDITION

Wednesday, 26 August 2026

Ten stories, filtered through ocean governance, hydrospatial science, and SIDS equity — curated for Francesca Adrienne, SHORE Institute.

01 UN Ocean Decade Call Closes in 5 Days ⚡

02 Commonwealth Blue Charter Incubator Opens ⚡

03 Deep-Sea Mining May Not Wait for the ISA

STORY 01 / 10

⚡ CLOSES 31 AUGUST, 23:59 UTC

The UN Ocean Decade's Next Call Closes in Five Days

The UN Ocean Decade's latest call for new Decade Actions closes in five days, and it is precisely the mechanism through which HARMONiSE could get formal UN Ocean Decade recognition without waiting for a bigger funding round first.

STORY NOTES

UNESCO's Intergovernmental Oceanographic Commission has opened Call for Decade Actions No. 11/2026, inviting new UN Ocean Decade Actions and Decade Contributions. The call responds to priorities set out in the Barcelona Statement, the outcome document from the 2024 Ocean Decade Conference, which drew more than 2,600 participants.

Applications close 31 August 2026 at 23:59 UTC, five days from this morning. Decade Actions and Decade Contributions carry no direct funding attached. Endorsement itself is the currency: a Decade Action listing signals UN recognition that positions a project for donor conversations that would otherwise start from zero credibility.

For an institute the size of SHORE, the bar is a properly scoped description of an existing or planned activity mapped against the Decade's stated priorities, not a full proposal with budget lines. Five days is tight but workable if HARMONiSE's current work already fits.

[oceandecade.org – Call for Decade Actions No. 11/2026](#)

STORY ARTICLE

UN Ocean Decade endorsement is not money. It never has been. What a Decade Action listing buys you is the line every subsequent proposal can open with: endorsed under the UN Decade of Ocean Science for Sustainable Development. That line changes how a reviewer reads everything that follows it, and Call for Decade Actions No. 11/2026, open now, closes 31 August 2026 at 23:59 UTC. Five days from this morning.

The call responds to the Barcelona Statement, the outcome document from the 2024 Ocean Decade Conference, where more than 2,600 participants set the science and knowledge priorities the Decade is meant to deliver against through 2030. You can register either a Decade Action, a defined project or programme, or a Decade Contribution, a smaller pledge of expertise, data, or infrastructure toward existing Decade Actions.

The application itself is not heavy. It asks for a description of the activity, how it maps onto stated Decade priorities, and what it contributes toward Decade outcomes, not a full proposal with budget lines and logframes. That is the actual argument for treating five days as workable rather than tight: the barrier here is clarity about what you are already doing, not a new document written from a blank page.

The honest objection is obvious. An unfunded UN endorsement is not revenue, and five days is a compressed timeline against running an institute solo. Both are true. Neither changes what the endorsement is worth once it exists. A funder evaluating a first-time grant application from an unfamiliar Seychelles-based institute reads it differently once that institute is listed as a UN Ocean Decade Action, because the vetting work that credential implies has already been done by someone else.

The practical read for HARMONiSE specifically: this call rewards a project already partway defined, not one invented for the deadline. If your hybrid bathymetry and mapping pipeline work already has a clear priority-area fit, drafting against Call 11/2026 in the next five days is closer to formatting existing thinking than generating new content.

Recognition without funding is still recognition. In a field where SHORE is competing for attention against institutions with decades of name recognition, a UN Decade Action listing is one of the few credentials available on a five-day timeline rather than a multi-month one.

[oceandecade.org – Call for Decade Actions No. 11/2026](#)

A £50,000 Door Just Opened Through Seychelles's Own Commonwealth Seat

This is a grant mechanism, up to £50,000, built for exactly the early-stage ocean conservation project scale SHORE operates at, and it runs through the same Commonwealth Blue Charter structure Seychelles already leads a working group inside.

STORY NOTES

The Commonwealth Secretariat and the Prince Albert II of Monaco Foundation have launched a new ocean protection alliance, implemented through the Commonwealth Blue Charter Project Incubator, which provides grants of up to £50,000 for Commonwealth countries to develop early-stage ocean conservation projects.

Five priority areas: reducing marine pollution, ecosystem restoration, sustainable fisheries, advancing the blue economy, and the ocean-climate nexus. The partnership explicitly centres Indigenous Peoples and local communities, youth, and gender-marginalised groups in project design, not as an add-on.

The initiative advances the Apia Commonwealth Ocean Declaration, adopted at the 2024 Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting. Seychelles already chairs the Blue Charter's Marine Protected Areas Action Group, a standing relationship this incubator sits directly inside.

[thecommonwealth.org – Commonwealth and Prince Albert II Foundation launch major ocean protection alliance](#)

STORY ARTICLE

£50,000 will not fund a multi-year mapping programme. It will fund exactly what an incubator grant is designed to fund: the scoping study, the pilot dataset, the proof of concept that turns an idea into something a larger funder can later evaluate on evidence rather than description. The Commonwealth Blue Charter Project Incubator, newly resourced through a partnership with the Prince Albert II of Monaco Foundation, is built for precisely that stage, and it runs through infrastructure you already sit inside.

The mechanism matters more than the ceiling. Seychelles chairs the Blue Charter's Marine Protected Areas Action Group, one of ten thematic groups under the Blue Charter umbrella. That is not a passive membership. It is a standing seat with existing relationships to the Commonwealth Secretariat's Blue Charter unit, the office running this incubator. A proposal from SHORE routed through that existing channel starts from a position most first-time Commonwealth grant applicants do not have.

The five priority areas, marine pollution, ecosystem restoration, sustainable fisheries, blue economy, ocean-climate nexus, are broad enough that a hydrospatial mapping pilot fits comfortably under at least two of them, depending on framing. The framing choice is not incidental. A proposal pitched as ecosystem restoration infrastructure competes against conservation projects; pitched as blue economy data infrastructure, it competes against a different, likely thinner, applicant pool.

The partnership's explicit centring of Indigenous Peoples, local communities, youth, and gender-marginalised groups in project design is worth taking seriously rather than treating as boilerplate. Funders are reading incubator applications for evidence of that centring built into the design, not appended as an outreach paragraph. A proposal naming specific community partners reads differently to a reviewer than one referencing engagement generically.

The counterargument: £50,000 is small enough that the application effort could outweigh the return, particularly against the several days other calls elsewhere are also asking for right now. That calculation changes once the incubator relationship becomes the on-ramp to any larger implementation grant the same partnership funds later, which is how incubator mechanisms are typically structured. The £50,000 is not the prize. It is the ticket to being considered for whatever comes after it.

No published deadline has surfaced yet for this specific call, the same lead-time argument that applied to the Commonwealth's SIDS climate fund earlier this week: the concept is worth drafting now, before a formal window opens, so the actual submission is a formality rather than a scramble.

[thecommonwealth.org – Commonwealth and Prince Albert II Foundation launch major ocean protection alliance](#)

Deep-Sea Mining in the Pacific May Not Wait for the ISA's Rules

You spent years as national focal point tracking the ISA from the inside, and this new analysis argues the mining code you watched being negotiated may simply get bypassed by 2027, starting with a US move that routes around the Authority entirely.

STORY NOTES

Lowy Institute researcher Dr Connor Graham, in "Fault lines beneath the Blue Pacific: Deep-sea mining and the future of Pacific unity," warns that commercial deep-sea mining for critical minerals could begin in the Pacific as early as 2027, without an internationally agreed regulatory framework in place.

The ISA has negotiated a mining code since 2014 without resolving environmental standards, liability, or benefit-sharing. Meanwhile a US executive order directs NOAA to issue seabed mining permits in areas beyond national jurisdiction, bypassing the ISA process outright, a direct challenge to the multilateral regime built under UNCLOS.

Pacific governments are split: some see seabed minerals as revenue, a growing coalition wants a moratorium over risk to fisheries, food security, and culture. That fracture, not the mining itself, is what the report frames as the deeper risk to Pacific unity.

[lowyinstitute.org – Fault lines beneath the Blue Pacific](https://lowyinstitute.org/fault-lines-beneath-the-blue-pacific)

STORY ARTICLE

The mining code was always the wrong thing to watch closely if the real risk was someone deciding not to wait for it. That is the argument in Lowy Institute researcher Dr Connor Graham's new analysis, "Fault lines beneath the Blue Pacific," which projects that commercial deep-sea mining for critical minerals could start in the Pacific as early as 2027, with or without the regulatory code the International Seabed Authority has spent more than a decade negotiating.

The ISA process, environmental standards, liability rules, benefit-sharing formulas, has been stuck since 2014 on exactly the questions that determine whether seabed mining is survivable for the ecosystems around it. That slowness was, for years, the point: an unfinished code meant no commercial exploitation could legally proceed. The report's central claim is that this protection was always conditional on every actor choosing to wait for consensus, and that condition no longer holds.

The clearest break is the US executive order directing NOAA to issue seabed mining permits in areas beyond national jurisdiction, which routes around the ISA's authority entirely rather than contesting it through the ISA's own process. For a governance regime built on the premise that UNCLOS-derived multilateral consensus is how the deep seabed gets regulated, a major power choosing to permit mining unilaterally is not a procedural dispute. It tests whether the framework holds when one significant actor decides it does not need it to.

What the report frames as the deeper Pacific risk is not the mining itself but the fracture it is producing among Pacific governments. Some island states see seabed minerals as a genuine revenue opportunity they have limited other options to access. A growing coalition wants a moratorium, citing risk to fisheries, food security, and cultural practice that a spill or extraction accident could not undo. That split matters because a fractured Pacific negotiating position is weaker in every subsequent multilateral forum, ISA Council sessions included, than a unified one would be.

Anyone who has sat inside ISA governance as a national focal point will recognise the pattern underneath this: consensus-based institutions move at the speed of their most reluctant member, and that speed becomes a liability the moment a powerful actor outside the consensus decides to move faster. The mining code negotiations were never going to resolve quickly. What changed is the assumption that slow negotiation functioned as a de facto moratorium.

The open question worth tracking through 2027 is not whether the ISA finishes its code in time. It almost certainly will not. It is whether unilateral action by one state triggers a broader unravelling of ISA authority, or whether the rest of the Council holds a unified line against it. Either answer reshapes what seabed governance means for every SIDS with a stake in how the deep ocean beyond its own EEZ gets managed.

lowyinstitute.org – [Fault lines beneath the Blue Pacific](#)

STORY 04 / 10

\$ market --sector geoai --range 2025-2030

The GeoAI Market Is Nearly Doubling by 2030. The Workflows Are the Real Story

The geospatial intelligence market funding automated GeoAI tools is projected to nearly double by 2030, and the workflow research behind that growth, physics-constrained models for coral, vessel, and habitat mapping, is the direct technical lineage HARMONiSE's pipeline sits in.

The global geospatial intelligence market is projected to grow from \$37.13 billion in 2025 to \$62.88 billion by 2030, driven substantially by GeoAI platforms automating image interpretation and predictive spatial analytics.

Underneath that figure sits a specific technical pattern: published GeoAI workflows for marine ecosystem monitoring now cover coral reef segmentation from underwater imagery, vessel detection and classification from satellite data, and habitat mapping, each built as a complete pipeline from raw imagery to usable maps, not an isolated model demonstration.

The market growth is a funding signal, not a technical one, but it tells you where institutional appetite for this category of tool is heading over the same five-year window HARMONiSE is meant to mature in.

[isprs-archives.copernicus.org – GeoAI for marine ecosystem monitoring: a complete workflow](https://isprs-archives.copernicus.org/GeoAI-for-marine-ecosystem-monitoring-a-complete-workflow)

\$37.13 billion. \$62.88 billion. Five years apart. That growth curve for the global geospatial intelligence market is not a headline about a single new tool. It is the aggregate signal of institutional money moving toward automated GeoAI platforms, image interpretation, predictive spatial analytics, at a pace that changes which mapping approaches attract funding attention over the next five years, precisely the window HARMONiSE needs to mature in.

What that market figure does not show is the technical substance underneath it, which is the more useful signal. Published GeoAI workflows for marine ecosystem monitoring have converged on a specific pattern: coral reef segmentation from underwater imagery, vessel detection and classification from satellite data, habitat mapping from multi-source remote sensing, each built as a complete pipeline running from raw imagery input to a usable map output, not a model demonstration stopping short of deployment.

That completeness matters more than any individual accuracy metric. A paper showing 94 percent classification accuracy on a benchmark dataset is a different artefact from a documented, end-to-end workflow someone else can actually adapt to their own imagery and their own coastline. The ISPRS workflow literature on marine ecosystem GeoAI is explicitly built as the second kind, worth studying closely when building your own pipeline rather than reinventing each stage independently.

The honest complication is that market growth funds the platforms and the compute, not automatically the domain expertise needed to apply them correctly to Seychelles's specific reef, lagoon, and coastal conditions. A \$62.88 billion market in 2030 will be dominated by tools built and validated on data from wherever the largest commercial and government contracts sit, which is unlikely to be small-island coastal waters by default.

That is the actual argument for tracking this literature closely rather than treating the market figure as reassurance. The workflows are increasingly available and increasingly documented. Whether they perform well on Seychelles's specific optical and ecological conditions is a validation question nobody outside SHORE has strong incentive to answer, which means it stays your work to do regardless of how large the underlying market gets.

Institutional funding tends to follow demonstrated capability, not aspiration. A hydrospatial observatory that can show a working, locally

validated GeoAI pipeline by the time this market curve peaks is positioned very differently, in any subsequent funding conversation, than one still building toward that capability once the money has already found other recipients.

[isprs-archives.copernicus.org – GeoAI for marine ecosystem monitoring: a complete workflow](#)

No. 05

One University Just Got a Seat Inside ISA Deliberations

A university just became the first Australian institution accredited as an ISA observer specifically to research deep-sea mining governance, and that is the exact civil-society-and-academia access point your ISA background tells you gets built once and rarely repeated.

STORY NOTES

The University of Technology Sydney, led by international relations scholar Dr Lai-Ha Chan, has obtained accredited observer status with the International Seabed Authority, enabling formal attendance at ISA Council and Assembly meetings. UTS is the first, and so far only, Australian university holding this status.

Chan describes the status as establishing UTS as "an engaged participant in global ocean governance," giving researchers a direct window into how the ISA develops its mining code, negotiations that remain closed to most outside observers beyond accredited NGOs and industry.

The ISA comprises 172 sovereign states; roughly 46 currently support a moratorium on deep-sea mining. Direct observer access to that split, rather than reconstructing it from public statements after the fact, is a meaningfully different research position.

[phys.org – Researchers gain access to crucial deliberations on deep-sea mining](#)

STORY ARTICLE

Observer status at the International Seabed Authority is not a formality. It is the difference between reading a communiqué written after a Council session and watching the negotiation that produced it, and it is a status the ISA does not hand out casually. The University of Technology Sydney, through international relations scholar Dr Lai-Ha Chan, has just become the first Australian university to hold it.

What that access actually confers is worth being specific about, because "observer status" undersells it. It means formal attendance at ISA Council and Assembly sessions, the rooms where the mining code negotiations that have stalled since 2014 actually happen, rather than the public summaries the ISA releases afterward. For a research question as contested as deep-sea mining governance, the difference between primary and secondary access to that process is substantial.

The number worth sitting with is the split inside the room UTS now has access to: 172 sovereign states inside the ISA, roughly 46 of them currently backing a moratorium on deep-sea mining. That is close to a quarter of the Authority's full membership, arguing from inside the institution for slowing down the exact process a growing number of external analyses, the Lowy Institute's among them, warn is already being bypassed unilaterally by non-consenting actors.

This is the version of science-to-policy access that most institutions never get and rarely think to pursue deliberately. Accredited observer status is typically the domain of established NGOs and industry bodies with years of standing relationships to the ISA Secretariat. A university securing it specifically to research governance, rather than to represent an industry or advocacy position, is a comparatively rare use of the mechanism, and one that widens who gets a documented, primary-source view of how this contested regime actually operates.

The relevant question for anyone who has worked inside ISA governance as a national focal point is whether this kind of academic observer access changes anything beyond the research record. It probably does not shift Council votes directly. What it does is create an independent, citable account of deliberations that would otherwise exist only in the ISA's own summaries and in whatever individual delegations choose to disclose, which matters considerably once a compliance dispute or a unilateral mining permit becomes contested in public.

The honest limit is that one Australian university's observer status does not solve the ISA's structural transparency problem. It is one additional set of eyes in a room that has historically had very few outside it. Whether other universities, especially ones based in states with a direct stake like Seychelles, pursue the same accreditation is the open question worth watching, because that is how a single institutional precedent becomes a pattern.

Source: phys.org, reporting on University of Technology Sydney's accredited observer status with the International Seabed Authority, August 2026.

New Data Complicates the High-Income SIDS Paradox

\$9,700

This new Center for Global Development analysis complicates the High-Income SIDS Paradox argument you've been building with real numbers, showing SIDS already receive six times the adaptation finance per capita of the average developing country, and that complication is worth engaging with directly rather than around.

STORY NOTES

A November 2025 Center for Global Development working paper by Jonathan Beynon complicates the standard SIDS finance narrative with hard numbers: SIDS average per capita GNI of \$9,700 sits 60 percent above the developing country average and eight times higher than Least Developed Countries.

SIDS also already receive more adaptation finance per capita than most other developing country groups: roughly \$29 per capita in 2022, six times the developing country average and three times the LDC average. Country-level variation is extreme: Tuvalu averaged over \$2,400 per person, while Nauru, the Marshall Islands, and Dominica received between \$190 and \$677.

On the Multidimensional Vulnerability Index built specifically to capture SIDS-specific risk beyond income, at least half of all SIDS rank in the bottom half for vulnerability across all three index levels, and just 11 percent fall in the top quartile for vulnerability, against 58 percent of LDCs.

[cgdev.org — Who's Really Most Vulnerable to Climate Change? SIDS, LDCs, and A daptation Finance](#)

STORY ARTICLE

The High-Income SIDS Paradox argument runs, roughly: Seychelles and states like it get priced out of concessional finance by GNI figures that ignore how narrow and exposed their economies actually are. A new Center for Global Development working paper by Jonathan Beynon puts numbers against that argument that complicate it more than they confirm it, and the complication is worth sitting with rather than working around.

The paper's first finding: SIDS average per capita GNI of \$9,700 sits 60 percent above the developing country average and eight times higher than Least Developed Countries. That is the income side of the paradox, familiar territory. The second finding is less familiar and considerably more uncomfortable for the standard advocacy framing. SIDS already receive more adaptation finance per capita than almost any other developing country group, roughly \$29 per capita in 2022, six times the developing country average and three times the LDC average.

The Multidimensional Vulnerability Index, the instrument built specifically to move concessional eligibility past raw GNI toward a fuller picture of SIDS-specific exposure, does not straightforwardly rescue the paradox argument either. At least half of all SIDS rank in the bottom half for vulnerability across all three levels the index measures. Only 11 percent of SIDS land in the top quartile for vulnerability, against 58 percent of LDCs. If the MVI is the corrective instrument the paradox argument has been

asking for, it is currently returning a more mixed verdict than the argument assumes.

None of this means the underlying claim, that GNI alone is a poor proxy for climate exposure in a small, geographically dispersed economy, is wrong. Country-level variation inside the SIDS average makes that clear on its own: Tuvalu averaged over \$2,400 per person in adaptation finance in 2022, while Nauru, the Marshall Islands, and Dominica received between \$190 and \$677. Averaging across a group with that much internal spread hides more than it reveals, in either direction, aggregate SIDS wealth or aggregate SIDS need.

What this paper actually argues for is a more disaggregated case, made country by country against the MVI's own more granular indicators, rather than a group-level appeal to "SIDS are vulnerable, income data understates it." Seychelles as a case study needs to show where its own MVI sub-indicators diverge from its GNI classification, not lean on a SIDS-wide average this data shows working against, as much as for, the argument.

The uncomfortable version of this finding, stated plainly: some of the loudest SIDS finance advocacy has been building on an aggregate claim that a serious independent analysis does not fully support. That is not a reason to abandon the argument. It is a reason to make a sharper one, built on Seychelles's specific MVI sub-scores rather than the SIDS category average, before a funder or a sceptical reviewer runs this exact CGD analysis against a weaker version of the same claim.

[cgdev.org – Who's Really Most Vulnerable to Climate Change? SIDS, LDCs, and Adaptation Finance](#)

STORY 07 / 10

"Ocean heat content, global sea level, and greenhouse gas concentration all set records in 2025. That is not three stories. It is one, told three times."

36th Annual State of the Climate Report

Ocean Heat, Sea Level, and Emissions All Broke Records in the Same Year

The 36th annual State of the Climate report puts a number on the ocean warming underneath every other climate story you track, and it is worth

having in your back pocket the next time someone treats ocean heat as background noise rather than the headline.

STORY NOTES

The 36th annual State of the Climate report, compiled by the American Meteorological Society with input from hundreds of scientists across more than 60 countries, confirms that greenhouse gas concentrations, global sea level, and ocean heat content all reached record highs in 2025.

Carbon Brief's parallel mid-year analysis raised the odds of 2026 becoming a new record-warm year to 35 percent, up from 19 percent in its April assessment, driven by one of the most rapidly intensifying El Niño events in the modern record forming across the tropical Pacific.

Ocean heat content is the slowest-moving and hardest-to-reverse of the three records. Once heat is absorbed into deep ocean layers, it stays there for decades regardless of what emissions do next, the argument for treating this record as the most consequential of the three, not the least visible.

[carbonbrief.org – State of the climate: rapidly developing El Niño raises chance of record-warm 2026](#)

STORY ARTICLE

Three records in one report, ocean heat content, global sea level, greenhouse gas concentration, read easily as three separate headlines. They are one story told three times. The 36th annual State of the Climate report, compiled by the American Meteorological Society with contributions from hundreds of scientists across more than 60 countries, confirms all three reached record highs in 2025, and the ocean is the mechanism connecting them, not a fourth item on the list.

Ocean heat content is the record worth focusing on specifically, because it behaves differently from the other two. Atmospheric greenhouse gas concentration and sea level both respond, eventually, to emissions trajectories. Ocean heat content is closer to a one-way ratchet: once heat is absorbed into deep ocean layers, it stays there for decades on its own physical timescale, regardless of what emissions policy does in the meantime. A record set in 2025 does not get walked back by a strong mitigation year in 2027.

Carbon Brief's parallel mid-year analysis adds the forward-looking piece: the odds of 2026 becoming a new record-warm year have risen to 35 percent, up from 19 percent in April, driven by one of the most rapidly intensifying El Niño events in the modern instrumental record, currently forming across the tropical Pacific. El Niño years pull surface heat that has been accumulating in the ocean back into the atmosphere, the physical link between last year's ocean heat record and this year's rising odds of an atmospheric one.

For ocean governance work specifically, this is the backdrop that makes every other story in this edition, deep-sea mining timelines, adaptation finance gaps, mapping investment, read as symptoms of a faster-moving underlying condition rather than parallel, unrelated tracks. The ocean is not a stable baseline against which climate impacts get measured. It is itself accumulating the change fastest and releasing it slowest, on a timescale longer than any single funding cycle or policy negotiation window.

The honest complication in citing a report like this is scale. A short Shorelines piece cannot do justice to a 36th annual assessment built from hundreds of contributing scientists, and reducing it to three headline records risks losing the report's own carefully hedged uncertainty language. The responsible use of this data point is as a framing device, not a full argument on its own: ocean heat is the slow variable underneath the faster-moving governance and finance stories this edition otherwise covers.

What is worth carrying forward is the ratchet framing, not just the record numbers. A record broken in atmospheric concentration can, in principle, be addressed by future emissions cuts. A record broken in accumulated ocean heat cannot be un-accumulated on any timeframe shorter than decades. That asymmetry is the argument for why ocean-focused governance work carries more urgency than its funding levels currently reflect.

[carbonbrief.org – State of the climate: rapidly developing El Niño raises chance of record-warm 2026](#)

STORY 08 / 10

What If Deep-Sea Mining Were Priced, Not Just Permitted?

This academic proposal for pollution charges on deep-sea mining is the kind of economic instrument argument that could reframe your own ISA governance writing away from pure moratorium advocacy toward a costed policy alternative.

STORY NOTES

A new peer-reviewed paper in the journal Oceans, "A Review of the Costs and Benefits of Deep Sea Mining and the Ways Pollution Charges Could Work," proposes pollution charges as a regulatory instrument for deep-sea mining, an economic mechanism distinct from the outright moratorium position much of the current advocacy coalition holds.

The pollution-charge model treats environmental damage from mining operations as an internalised cost rather than an externality regulators discover afterward, a standard tool in other extractive-industry regulation with limited application to

deep-sea contexts specifically because baseline ecological damage data has been so sparse.

For anyone writing into the ISA mining code debate, a costed pollution-charge proposal is a different kind of argument than a moratorium position, one aimed at a Council trying to finish a mining code rather than one trying to avoid finishing it.

[doi.org – A Review of the Costs and Benefits of Deep Sea Mining and the Ways Pollution Charges Could Work](#)

STORY ARTICLE

Most of the public argument over deep-sea mining sorts into two camps: proceed under whatever code the ISA eventually finishes, or stop entirely until enough is known to proceed safely. A new

peer-reviewed paper in the journal Oceans argues for a third position that gets far less coverage, treating environmental damage as a cost to be priced and charged for, not an outcome to be permitted or prohibited outright.

The pollution-charge model is not a novel economic instrument in the abstract. Carbon pricing, extraction royalties, and effluent charges in other extractive industries all work from the same underlying logic: make the actor causing environmental damage bear its cost directly, rather than treating that damage as an externality regulators discover and litigate after the fact. What is novel is applying that logic specifically to deep-sea mining, an environment where baseline ecological data is thin enough that pricing damage accurately is a genuinely harder problem than in most terrestrial extractive contexts.

That difficulty is also the paper's most useful contribution, more than the pricing mechanism itself. Pollution charges only function as intended if the underlying damage can be measured and attributed with reasonable confidence. For the deep seabed, where baseline biodiversity surveys remain incomplete across most prospective mining zones, a pollution-charge regime forces exactly the kind of ecological baseline data collection that a straightforward permit-or-prohibit regime does not require upfront.

For anyone writing into the ISA mining code debate, and this includes any future Shorelines piece engaging with the deep-sea mining question directly, a costed pollution-charge proposal is a materially different kind of argument than a moratorium position. A moratorium argument is aimed at delaying the process. A pollution-charge argument is aimed at Council members actively trying to

finish a mining code, offering a mechanism they could plausibly adopt rather than a position they would need to abandon their current negotiating goal to accept.

The honest limitation is that pricing mechanisms depend entirely on enforcement capacity the ISA does not currently demonstrate elsewhere in its regulatory record. A pollution charge that goes uncollected, or that gets negotiated down through the same consensus-seeking process that has stalled the mining code itself for over a decade, delivers little more protection than no charge at all. The mechanism is only as strong as the institution collecting it.

What makes this worth tracking regardless of that limitation is where the argument sits in the current ISA debate. Council members under pressure to finish a mining code, and increasingly under pressure from unilateral action that threatens to make the code irrelevant before it is finished, have an incentive to adopt a mechanism that lets them claim environmental seriousness without abandoning the extraction timeline entirely. A pollution-charge framework is exactly that kind of politically viable middle position, which is why it deserves more attention in ocean governance writing than it is currently getting.

[doi.org – A Review of the Costs and Benefits of Deep Sea Mining and the Ways Pollution Charges Could Work](#)

STORY 09 / 10

The UK Wrote Ocean Protection Into Its Five-Year SIDS Strategy

The UK just published a five-year SIDS strategy built explicitly around ocean protection and the 30x30 target, and it is a bilateral partnership door that opened in January and that you have not yet tested for Seychelles specifically.

STORY NOTES

The UK government published its Small Island Developing States Strategy 2026-2030 in January 2026, structured around climate adaptation and resilience, aid effectiveness, inclusive governance, global financial system reform, ocean and nature protection, and resilient economic diversification.

The ocean and nature protection strand explicitly supports the UK's Global Biodiversity Framework commitment to protect at least 30 percent of the global

ocean by 2030, positioning SIDS partnerships as delivery infrastructure for that target rather than a separate development programme running alongside it.

The strategy replaces the UK's 2022-2026 SIDS approach, and its emphasis on reforming the global financial system for SIDS access sits directly alongside the same concessional-finance eligibility debate the vulnerability paradox research earlier in this edition is complicating with hard numbers.

[gov.uk – UK Small Island Developing States Strategy 2026-2030](#)

STORY ARTICLE

A bilateral strategy document rarely gets treated as urgent, which is exactly why the UK's Small Island Developing States Strategy 2026-2030, published quietly in January this year, has attracted less attention from SIDS institutions than its content justifies. It sets out five years of UK government priority: climate adaptation, aid effectiveness, inclusive governance, global financial system reform, ocean and nature protection, and resilient economic growth, explicitly framed around SIDS partnerships rather than a generic development programme that happens to include them.

The ocean and nature protection strand is the one worth reading most closely. It is framed as direct delivery infrastructure for the UK's Global Biodiversity Framework commitment to protect at least 30 percent of the global ocean by 2030, not a parallel conservation programme running alongside that target. That framing matters because it means SIDS ocean partnerships are being evaluated, at least in part, against a hard UK-side numerical commitment with its own accountability pressure, rather than against a softer aid-effectiveness metric that is easier to deprioritise when budgets tighten.

The financial system reform strand sits directly next to the concessional-finance eligibility debate the earlier story on the Multidimensional Vulnerability Index complicates with real numbers. A UK strategy explicitly naming global financial system reform as a five-year priority is a different kind of partner than one treating SIDS finance access as a settled question. Whether that stated priority translates into UK support for MVI-based eligibility reform specifically, rather than remaining a general commitment, is the detail worth tracking in how this strategy gets implemented over its first year.

What the strategy does not resolve is where any individual SIDS, Seychelles included, sits in the UK's implementation priorities across the 39 eligible states. A five-year strategy naming ocean protection as a strand is not the same as a bilateral programme with Seychelles specifically, and the distance between those two things is where the actual opportunity, or the actual gap, sits for the next twelve months.

The practical opening this creates is a direct one: a strategy this freshly published, replacing a 2022-2026 predecessor, is in its early implementation phase right now, which is when country teams inside the relevant UK department are still shaping which SIDS partnerships get resourced first. That is a materially better moment to raise SHORE's hydrospatial mapping work as a concrete ocean-protection delivery partner than approaching the same conversation once implementation priorities across all 39 states are already locked in.

The honest caveat is that strategy documents of this kind routinely under-deliver against their stated ambition, and a five-year framework naming ocean protection as a priority is not a guarantee of funded programming reaching any specific state. That is the argument for engaging early and specifically, rather than waiting to see which SIDS the UK chooses to prioritise on its own initiative.

What Seychelles's Blue Bond Actually Proved

Your own country's blue bond, the one that inspired Gabon and Ecuador to issue their own, is the single strongest home-turf case study SHORE has for demonstrating that innovative ocean finance actually works, and it is worth returning to as a live reference rather than an origin story.

STORY NOTES

Seychelles's 2018 sovereign blue bond, a \$15 million private placement, combined a \$5 million World Bank IBRD guarantee with a \$5 million Global Environment Facility concessional grant to make the bond viable for private investors including Calvert Impact Capital, Nuveen, and Prudential Financial.

Proceeds expanded marine protected areas to 30 percent of Seychelles's exclusive economic zone and funded fisheries governance improvements, with \$3 million channelled through SeyCCAT for community grants and the remaining \$12 million managed by the Development Bank of Seychelles for blue economy lending.

The model has since been replicated by Gabon in 2022 and Ecuador in 2024, but a recent retrospective is explicit that the model requires robust institutions, transparent governance, technical capacity, and an investable project pipeline that not every island nation currently has in place.

[ipsnews.net – Seychelles' Blue Bond: Turning Ocean Vision into Action](#)

STORY ARTICLE

Seychelles issued the world's first sovereign blue bond in 2018, and by now that fact risks being cited so often it stops functioning as an argument and starts functioning as a slogan. A closer look at what the \$15 million bond actually did, and what a recent retrospective says is required to replicate it, is a stronger case for SHORE's work than the headline alone.

The structure is the part worth remembering precisely. \$15 million from private investors, Calvert Impact Capital, Nuveen, and Prudential Financial among them, only became viable because a \$5 million World Bank IBRD

guarantee and a \$5 million Global Environment Facility concessional grant absorbed enough of the risk that private capital was willing to price the remainder reasonably. That is not a story about a small island nation persuading markets to care about ocean conservation on its own. It is a story about blended finance engineering that made a genuinely novel instrument bankable.

What the money funded matters as much as how it was raised. Proceeds expanded marine protected area coverage to 30 percent of Seychelles's exclusive economic zone, improved fisheries governance, and financed blue economy lending through the Development Bank of Seychelles, with \$3 million routed through SeyCCAT specifically for community-level grants. That is a concrete, auditable delivery record spanning conservation, governance, and community finance, seven years and counting, not a pledge still awaiting implementation.

The replication record is the part that actually validates the model, more than Seychelles's own results do in isolation. Gabon issued a comparable bond in 2022, Ecuador in 2024. Two additional sovereign issuances, each adapting the same blended-guarantee structure to a different country's debt profile and conservation priorities, is evidence the mechanism generalises rather than depending on conditions unique to Seychelles.

The honest complication, and the reason this is not a template every SIDS can simply copy, is institutional. A recent retrospective on the bond states plainly that the model requires robust institutions, transparent governance, technical capacity, and a pipeline of investable projects already built before the finance can attach to it. Not every island nation currently has all four in place, and a bond structure this dependent on institutional credibility does not transfer cleanly to a state still building that credibility.

That institutional dependency is the actual argument for why this case study belongs in SHORE's own material, not as an inspiring precedent but as a diagnostic. Seychelles's blue bond worked because the underlying governance capacity existed to make it credible to guarantors and investors. Any pitch positioning SHORE's hydrosatial data work as blue-finance-adjacent infrastructure should make that governance-capacity argument explicitly, using Seychelles's own bond as the demonstrated proof rather than assuming the connection is obvious.

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